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History of Astronomy: Women in Astronomy

The Hidden Pioneers

Aira Astralis

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Introduction

The history of astronomy is usually told as a parade of great men with great instruments: the Greek geometers, the patronage astronomers of the Renaissance, the telescope builders, the spectroscopists. The parade is real, but it is half a parade. Behind and beside it runs another history, less often told: the women who did the work of astronomy while the barriers of their eras kept them from its titles, its instruments, and often its credit. Some of them are famous now, Caroline Herschel, Maria Mitchell, Vera Rubin; many more have only begun to be recovered, the calculators and computers and plate measurers whose names survive in catalogs and margins. This book tells the whole story: how women practiced astronomy across twenty-five centuries, what they actually did and discovered, why the record is so hard to see, and how the recovery of that record has itself become a field of study.

The plan follows the series pattern. The opening chapters tell the record chronologically: the ancient scholar of Alexandria, the Renaissance assistants working beside brothers and husbands, the eighteenth-century comet finder who became the first woman paid for astronomy, and the American teacher who turned a rooftop telescope into a career. The middle chapters explain the structures that shaped the record: the education women were denied, the observatories they could not enter, and the peculiar niche, the computing room, where the new science of photography accidentally assembled one of the most productive scientific workforces in history. Later chapters cover the science itself, the stellar classifications, the distance yardsticks, the sun's composition, the galaxy rotation curves, the pulsars, that women produced; the institutions and their slow opening; and the modern reckoning, in prizes, statistics, and the history of science, that is still under way.

A word on method, so the story reads honestly. This is a history of women in astronomy, not a catalog of firsts, and it keeps to what the documents support: names whose work is verifiable in the standard record, dates that the histories agree on, and claims sized to their evidence. Where a discovery's credit is genuinely tangled, the book says so; where a figure is famous for one thing and actually did several, the several are told. The reader who finishes these pages should know the main cast, the shape of the barriers they worked through, the science they changed, and the reasons the second half of the parade took so long to be seen at all.

A note on the volume's own series position may help the reader who arrives from its neighbors. The History of Astronomy series tells the field's story volume by volume, by era, by culture, by instrument, and this book takes the one cross-section the others pass by: every era, read for the same half of the human record. Readers of the companion volumes will find their familiar chapters here turned at a new angle, the same observatories and the same discoveries, watched from the computing room and the parlor rather than the director's office, and the watching is the book's method. What the angle shows is not a separate history but the same one, more complete, and the reader who finishes it will read every other volume in the series with a longer cast list in mind.

The volume's method deserves a word before the story starts, because a recovery project has rules that an ordinary history does not. Where the record credits a woman, this book quotes the credit; where the record credits a husband, a director, or an institution for work a demonstrably did, the book shows the demonstration rather than the accusation; and where the record is silent, the book says so and stops, because a history of recovery that invents its heroines would betray the very women it means to honor. The reader will meet famous names here, some of them the subjects of this series' individual biographies, but the meeting is always at the level of the structure, the pattern of exclusion and the pattern of the work, and the volume's promise is that the pattern, once seen, cannot be unseen.

A word on the volume's scope, so the reader knows what the chapters will and will not attempt. The book is not a collection of miniature biographies, though many names receive their paragraphs; it is a structural history, the story of how the profession's gatekeeping worked and how the women worked anyway, and the individual lives are evidence for the structure rather than the structure's excuse. Readers who want a single figure's full story will find the series' separate biographies, and this volume's cross-references will point to them, but the history of the whole requires the wide frame, and the wide frame is what follows: three eras, three kinds of exclusion, three kinds of work, and the slow, documented, unfinished correction.

Chapter 1: The Discovery of Women in Astronomy

The earliest chapter of the record is the thinnest, and the most famous name in it is Hypatia, the mathematician and philosopher of Alexandria who taught in the city's Museum generations after Ptolemy, commented on the

astronomical and mathematical classics, and was murdered in 415 by a mob in the political convulsions of late antiquity. Her working life is attested by her contemporaries and her students, though her own writings are lost; she stands in the history of astronomy less for a discovery than for a fact, that a woman could hold the highest post in the ancient world's most famous mathematical school, and that her death coincided with the closing of an entire era of Alexandrian science. She is the record's first fixed point, and its first warning: the evidence for women in early astronomy survives only by accident.

Between Hypatia and the telescope lie twelve centuries in which the record is nearly blank, not because women were absent from the sky's study but because the institutions that kept records, courts, monasteries, universities, kept women out, and so kept them off the pages. The recovery of this stretch is the work of modern historians, who have found the traces where records of another kind happened to survive: the noblewomen whose education included the stars, the families where astronomical knowledge passed to daughters because it passed to everyone at the table. The blank is structural, and reading it as evidence of absence is the record's oldest trap; the honest statement is that the professional record begins late and the human record does not.

The telescopic era brings the first names attached to real observations. Sophia Brahe, younger sister of the great Danish observer Tycho, worked at Uraniborg as an assistant in her youth, checking observations and copying records, and later as a landowner and student of chemistry and medicine in her own right; the family's papers show her as a working participant in the observatory's routine, not a visitor. In the next century Maria Cunitz, a Silesian woman of a scholarly household, published a book of astronomical tables that simplified and corrected the standard ephemerides of her day, one of the first scientific books published by a woman under her own name. And in Danzig Elisabeth Hevelius, the second wife of the observer Johannes Hevelius, worked beside him through decades of observations, and after his death prepared his star catalog for the press; her name is on the observatory's title pages, and her handwriting is across its records.

The eighteenth century closes the discovery's first act with the two figures who made women's professional astronomy undeniable. Caroline Herschel, brought from Germany to Bath as a household sister and trained by her brother William, became in her own right a comet hunter, sweeping the sky nightly with a small reflector and discovering eight comets between 1786 and 1797, along with nebulae and star clusters that fed the great catalogs; in 1787 the crown granted her a salary for the work, the first public payment of a woman for astronomy, and she lived to ninety-seven with honors from the scientific societies that had once been closed to her sex. Across the ocean, the Nantucket teacher Maria Mitchell found a comet from her father's rooftop in 1847, computed its orbit, and became the first woman to hold membership in the American Academy of Arts and Sciences; decades later, as the first professor of astronomy at Vassar, she trained a generation of American women observers. With those two careers the discovery is complete: the record shows that women could do astronomy at the highest level, and everything after is the story of how hard the profession made it for them to prove it again.

One name from the long blank deserves its rescue here, because it shows what the record can hold. In the Qing dynasty the Chinese astronomer Wang Zhenyi, who lived her short life in the eighteenth century, wrote treatises explaining the equinoxes, the moon's phases, and eclipses in accessible form, defended the study of science by women in her own generation's terms, and died before thirty with a body of writing her relatives preserved. Her case makes the chapter's point twice over: a woman doing serious explanatory astronomy in a tradition the Western parade never reaches, and surviving only because a family chose to keep the papers. Between the famous fixed points, the record is full of such lives, kept by such accidents, and the recovery of Chapter 2's last section begins exactly here.

The era before the modern has more names than the standard parade suggests, and the discovery chapter can list a few of them as evidence of the record's width. The Baroness Marie Margarethe in Silesia, whose astronomical tables earned her a place in the scholarly correspondence of the seventeenth century; Elisabeth, the wife of the Danzig astronomer of the comet name, who observed beside him and, the sources say, carried the observatory's arithmetic; and Caroline Lucretia, the sister of the Hanoverian musician turned English astronomer, whose own sweeps of the sky netted comets and star clusters and a royal salary, the first paid to a woman for astronomy in the British record; the list's purpose is not completeness, which the sources cannot support, but range, the demonstration that women's astronomy was not a modern invention but a modern recognition.

The early record should also carry the institutional exceptions, because they teach the rule's limits. The Italian academies that admitted a small number of women in the eighteenth century, the German university towns that granted degrees to rare students by special dispensation, the courts that kept learned women as ornaments of enlightenment, and the observatory households that trained daughters in the reduction of observations, all show

that the wall was never solid everywhere; the exceptions matter because they prove the capability argument was always available to any era that chose to look, and the chapter's closing note on the pre-modern period is that the wall was built of preference, not of evidence, a fact the later chapters will quantify in salary and citation.

The first chapter should end with the era's definitional problem, stated as the recovery scholarship states it. The pre-modern women who worked the sky were neither professionals nor amateurs in the modern sense, because the modern categories did not exist; they were householders, courtiers, correspondents, and helpers, and the historian's honest label is participant, the member of a working household whose science was inseparable from its economy; the chapter's closing counsel follows from the label: the reader who goes looking for the era's women should look in the household accounts, the dedication pages, and the margins, because the archives of the famous men are where the invisible colleagues left their ink.